

POST 134: Authoritarian Politics

Fall 2026

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Office location: Avery 214

Class sessions: Mondays, 2:45 – 5:30 p.m.

Class location: Avery Hall 202

Office hours: Mondays 11:00 a.m. – 1:30 p.m., or by appointment.



Welcome to Authoritarian Politics! This syllabus will serve as a guide for this course, as it contains information about class expectations, reading materials, assignments, the midterm, the final, and the grading scale. It also contains the schedule we will follow unless indicated otherwise.

This course can be reading intensive, but fear not! We're here to learn from each other and with each other. There will be more readings during some days than others, so make sure to pay attention when you'll need to spend more time on the class readings. Some of the readings (including the main book) may include statistical analysis and techniques. However, students are not required to have previous statistical knowledge to enroll or do well in class. The goal is to be familiar with the authors' *main arguments* and to become familiar with qualitative and quantitative approaches to social science and the study of autocracies. All materials are posted on the class's Canvas page, with exception of the main book and unless indicated otherwise.

Most importantly, this is a **no technology class**. While using a laptop can appear more convenient, writing using pen and paper can be more efficient in developing important thinking and critical analysis skills (see <https://www.nature.com/articles/s44222-025-00323-4>). It also helps in processing what is being read and discussed in class and at home. Given the class's length, we will also a 15-minute break half-way through the class to recoup.

COURSE DESCRIPTION

Despite the global expansion of democracy since the 1990s, many countries have maintained some variety of authoritarian rule. Moreover, authoritarianism (and authoritarian-friendly policies) has become more popular in the last decade. This class surveys major topics in the development of authoritarianism and its survival. We will focus on a central question: How do we define autocracy and autocratic regimes, and how do autocrats retain power? During this course, we will examine the social and economic origins of autocracy, its implications for policy, and other related topics. This course is not aimed at judging whether one type of regime is better than another. Instead, we will learn and critically assess the factors that have led to the emergence of authoritarianism, autocratic survival and/or regime transition. The course draws from a range of disciplines—primarily political science, economics, sociology, and history.

As a reminder, this course is *reading intensive* and this is also a *no technology* class. Yet don't be intimidated or discouraged! Students are not expected to memorize the material. Instead, students are expected to critically read the material, become familiar with the authors' main arguments, and come to class ready to examine and discuss the different frameworks that are presented to better understand autocratic regimes. If there are questions or something needs clarification, do not hesitate to share and/or ask!

By the end of this course, students will be able to:

OBJECTIVES	ASSESSMENT
Identify, understand, and critically examine the main frameworks to study autocratic regimes and governments.	Weekly in-class participation, students' reading responses/exercises, and midterm.
Describe and contrast the characteristics of different autocratic regimes.	
Understand and evaluate the factors and processes associated with autocracy, its survival, and democratic backsliding.	
Examine the main issues and concerns associated with autocratic governments, including repression, political oppression, government legitimatization, and autocratic endurance.	Students' reading responses/exercises, midterm, and final.
Analyze how international and domestic structures can shape and affect autocratic institutions and their survival.	

CLASS MATERIALS AND REQUIREMENTS

This course will use one main book, in addition to readings that have been posted in Canvas, in the Files tab, in "Readings."

- Svolik, Milan. *The Politics of Authoritarian Rule* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2012).
 ****This is a book with many game-theory models (aka: algebraic operations and proofs). Do not feel scared by them. Focus on the logic and reasoning behind each argument. This means that, as you read the book, you can skim/skip the mathematical operations. Yet make sure to pay attention to what the author is arguing, what factors he is using and testing to explain his arguments, and what examples are used.*

Class components:

Class engagement	15%
Reading comprehension responses (15% each)	30%
In-class midterm	20%
In-class final	20%
Class exercise	15%
TOTAL	100%

1. Class engagement (15%)

Students are expected to read each week's assigned materials and contribute to class discussions. This is a small class, so it is essential for students to participate to make it as interactive as possible. As your instructor, I'm not seeking for perfection; instead, I look forward to students' willingness to learn, listen, and grow as professionals and individuals. We all come from different backgrounds and embody many distinct stories, so be respectful at all instances.

2. Reading comprehension responses (30%)

Students are expected to write (2) critical reading responses. One must be due by **September 28**, by 11:59 p.m. (Pacific Time) and the other one by **November 16**, by 11:59 p.m. (Pacific Time). Each response should be 4 pages (max.) in length, 12-point font (Calibri, Times New Roman or equivalent), and 1.5-spaced. These readings responses must examine at least two readings that are covered in class and cannot include material outside of the class's syllabus. A rubric will be provided within the first two weeks of classes. If students provide only summaries of the readings, they will receive no more than 50% of the grade.

If the use of AI or any LLM is suspected and/or detected, the assignment will receive a zero.

3. In-class midterm (20%)

The midterm will take place during class time on **October 12**, in which students will be given short-answer and long-answer (essay) questions.

4. In-class exercise (15%)

Students will participate in a graded exercise during the second half of class time on **November 9**.

5. In-class final (20%)

The in-class final will take place on **December 7**.

Grading scale:

The grading scale for this class is as follow:

A	95-100	C	73-76
A-	90-94	C-	70-72
B+	87-89	D+	67-69
B	83-86	D	63-66
B-	80-82	D-	60-62
C+	77-79	F	59 and below

CLASS POLICIES**NO TECH CLASS**

During class time, we will try to stay present in the classroom and focus on listening to others and ourselves. This means that students should not take out their laptop or tablet during class. If you have a phone, please keep it silenced in your bag or pocket. The use artificial technology (AI or LLM) is also prohibited during class time and for the assigned work. If you like to take notes, please bring a notebook and a writing instrument. If you would like to consult the readings during discussion, please bring a hard copy to class.

If a student needs accommodations, please let me know and contact the corresponding office to provide the necessary documentation to best support you in the classroom (also see Accommodations).

ACADEMIC INTEGRITY AND AI/LLM POLICY

As a college that prioritizes reflective and creative learning, students are expected to adhere to the College's Code of Student Conduct, which upholds academic integrity and prohibits academic dishonesty, including those forms of academic dishonesty that are listed in the Pitzer College Student Handbook (Section III.C). Failure to uphold these standards can result in a failing grade for the assignment in question, or even a failing grade for the entire course.

Do not use AI and/or LLM tools for any part of your work in this class. Submitting work as your own that was generated by AI is **plagiarism** and falls under the purview of Pitzer's academic integrity policy.

ACCOMMODATIONS

If a student needs academic accommodations and/or academic support, please inform me as soon as possible (within the first two weeks of classes). In addition, please contact the Pitzer Office of Academic Support Services (PASS) at academicsupport@pitzer.edu or 909-607-0213, especially when needing to request accommodations for exams. Remember that the process is student-led and PASS has set deadlines for when these notices are sent.

MAKE-UP REQUIREMENTS

There will be **no make-up assignments and tests for unexcused absences**. Acceptable excuses, which include medical, family, or other emergencies and official college-related business, must be provided to me in writing in advance to be considered. Students who are unable to complete a

requirement for legitimate reasons that do not qualify as excused under university guidelines, and who provide notification may, at my discretion, complete a requirement belatedly. Any requirement turned in on after the deadline will incur a penalty of **1/4 of your grade per day late**. Submissions after one week from the original deadline will not be accepted and will be assigned a grade of zero.

GRADING POLICY

Students may contest the grade on an exam and/or assignment due to **clerical error** up to one week after it is returned. Students will need to submit a written description of the error they believe occurred along with the exam and/or assignment. Clerical mistakes will be corrected, and the corresponding partial credit will be provided. This process does not guarantee the grade to go up. In addition, **everything submitted by students is graded according to the criteria and rubric provided in the class; thus, requests for regrading that are not due to clerical error will not be accepted.**

E-MAIL POLICY

Students are expected to send respectful and complete email messages (i.e., full sentences). I will address you with courtesy and respect, and I will try to reply to students' messages in a timely manner. Please allow a wait-period of 48 hours after you send a message for me to email back. I will try my best to respond as soon as I can.

CLASS SCHEDULE

Aug 31: Introduction

- No readings. We will go over the syllabus, class requirements, and discuss some issues related to authoritarianism.

Sep 6: Labor Day (no class)

Sep 14: What is autocracy? How do we measure it?

- Svolik, chapters 1 and 2
- Read the following pieces from this issue of authoritarianism edited by Marlies Glasius, "Reconceptualizing Authoritarianism," *APSA Comparative Democratization*, Vol. 13, No. 2, June 2015.
 - o Glasius, Marlies, "Introducing the Symposium and a Research Note."
 - o Wedeen, Lisa, "Authoritarianism and the Problem of Democratic Distinction."
 - o Ramos Pinto, Pedro, "Authoritarianism and Globalization in Historical Perspectives."
- Munck, Gerardo, "Drawing Boundaries: How to Craft Intermediate Regime Categories," in *Electoral Authoritarianism: The Dynamics of Unfree Competition*, 2006, pp. 27-40.

Sep 21: Autocratic institutions and personal dictatorships

- Svolik, chapter 3 and 4

- Meng, Anne, Jack Paine, and Robert Powell, "Authoritarian power sharing: Concepts, mechanisms, and strategies," *Annual Review of Political Science* 26, No. 1, 2023, pp. 153-173.
- Hale, Henry, "Eurasian Politics as Hybrid Regimes: The Case of Putin's Russia," *Journal of Eurasian Studies* 1(1), 2010, pp. 33-41.
- Shirk, Susan. "China in Xi's New Era": The Return to Personalistic Rule," *Journal of Democracy*, Vol. 29, No. 2, 2018, pp. 22-36.

Optional:

- Brancati, Daw, "Democratic Authoritarianism," *Annual Review of Political Science*, Vol. 17, 2014, pp. 313-326.

Sep 28: Military dictatorships and single party rule

First reading response due by 11:59 p.m. (Pacific Time)

- Svolik, chapters 5 and 6
- Greene K., "The Political Economy of Authoritarian Single-Party Dominance," *Comparative Political Studies*, 43(7), 2010, pp. 807-834.
- In-class video: "Trujillo: The Power of the Generalissimo"

Oct 5: Sharing power and leadership succession autocracies

- Svolik, chapters 4 (review) and 7
- Geddes Barbara, Joseph Wright, Erica Frantz. Chapter 6, "Why Parties and Elections in Dictatorships?" *How Dictatorships Work: Power, Personalization, and Collapse*. Cambridge University Press, 2018, pp. 177-217.
- Meng, Anne. "Winning the Game of Thrones: Leadership Succession in Modern Autocracies," *Journal of Conflict Resolution*, 2020, pp. 950-981.

Oct 12: **In-class midterm**

Please bring some pens. I will provide the exam and the scratch paper (if needed).

Oct 19: Fall break

Oct 26: Electoral and competitive authoritarianism

- Schedler, Andreas, "Chapter 1: The Logic of Electoral Authoritarianism" in *Electoral Authoritarianism: The Dynamics of Unfree Competition*, 2006, pp. 1-23.
- Levitsky, Steven, and Lucan A. Way, "Elections Without Democracy: The Rise of Competitive Authoritarianism." *Journal of Democracy*, 13(2), 2002, pp. 51-65.
- Case, William, Chapter 6: Manipulative Skills: How Do Rulers Control the Electoral Arena? in *Electoral Authoritarianism: The Dynamics of Unfree Competition*, 2006, pp. 95-112.

Optional:

- Levitsky, Steven, and Lucan A. Way, "The New Competitive Authoritarianism," *Journal of Democracy*, Vol. 31, No. 1, 2020, pp. 51-65.

- Hartlyn, Jonathan and Jennifer McCoy (2006). "Chapter 3: Observer Paradoxes: How to Assess Electoral Manipulation," in *Electoral Authoritarianism: The Dynamics of Unfree Competition*, pp. 41-56.
- Magaloni, Beatriz (2010.) "The Game of Electoral Fraud and the Ousting of Authoritarian Rule." *American Journal of Political Science*, 54 (3), 2010, pp. 751–765.

Nov 2: The economics of autocracies

- Foa, Roberto Stefan, "Modernization and Authoritarianism," *Journal of Democracy*, Vol. 29, No. 3, 2018, pp. 129-140.
- Olson, Mancur, "Dictatorship, Democracy, and Development", *American Political Science Review* 87(3), 1993, pp. 567-576.
- Rosenfeld, Brynn, *The Autocratic Middle Class: How State Dependency Reduces the Demand for Democracy* (Princeton: Princeton University Press), 2021. Read chapters 1, 2, and 4.

Optional:

- Wu, Chin-en (2012). "When Is Democracy Better for Economic Performance and When Is It Not: The Interaction Between Polity and Structural Factors." *Studies in Comparative International Development* 47, pp. 365-388.

Nov 9: Protests, Social Movements, and Democracy

We will hold our in-class exercise during the second half of the class.

- Kingston, Paul. Chapter 6: The Ebbing and Flowing of Political Opportunity Structures: Revolution, Counterrevolution, and the Arab Uprisings" in *Protest and Democracy* edited by Moisés Arce and Roberta Rice (Canada: University of Calgary Press), 2019, pp. 119-143.
- O'Brien, Thomas. "Populism, Protest, and Democracy in the Twenty-First Century," *Contemporary Social Science*, Vol. 10, No. 4, 2015, pp. 337-348.
- Rosenfeld, Brynn, *The Autocratic Middle Class: How State Dependency Reduces the Demand for Democracy* (Princeton: Princeton University Press), 2021. Read chapters 6 and 7.

Optional:

- Christensen, Darin and Francisco Garfias, "Can You Hear Me Now? How Communication Technology Affects Protest and Repression," *Quarterly Journal of Political Science* 13, 2018, pp. 89-117.
- McCabe, Riley and Samuel Brannen, "Global Political Protests and the Future of Democracy," via *Center for Strategic & International Studies (CSIS)*, 2021. Available at <https://www.csis.org/analysis/global-political-protests-and-future-democracy>
- Gause, F. G., "Why Middle East Studies Missed the Arab Spring: The Myth of Authoritarian Stability," *Foreign Affairs*, Vol. 90, 2011, pp. 81-90.
- Kuran, T., "Now Out of Never: The Element of Surprise in the East European Revolution of 1989," *World Politics* 44(1), 1991, pp. 7-48.

Nov 16: Repression and communication control

Second reading response due by 11:59 p.m. (Pacific Time)

- Christensen, Darin and Francisco Garfias, "Can You Hear Me Now? How Communication Technology Affects Protest and Repression," *Quarterly Journal of Political Science* 13, 2018, pp. 89-117.
- Hoffman, Samantha, "China's Tech-Enhanced Authoritarianism," *Journal of Democracy*, Vol. 33, No. 2, 2022, pp. 76-89.
- Vanderhill, Rachel. 2020. "Censorship, Surveillance, and Propaganda: The Cases of Iran and Russia." *Autocracy and Resistance in the Internet Age*. Boulder, USA: Lynne Rienner Publishers, 2020, pp. 55-108.
- Wasserman, Herman, Tanja Bosch and Wallace Chuma, "Communication from above and below: Media, Protest, and Democracy," *POLITIKON*, Vol. 45, No. 3, 2018, pp. 368-386.

Nov 23: Democracy and its vulnerabilities

- Dinas, Elias and Ksenia Northmore Ball, "The Ideological Shadow of Authoritarianism," *Comparative Political Studies*, Vol. 53, Issue 12, 2020, pp. 1957-1991.
- Ginsburg, Tom, and Aziz Huq, "Democracy's Near Misses." *Journal of Democracy* 29, no. 4, 2018, pp. 16-30.
- Graham, Matthew, and Milan Svolik, "Democracy in America? Partisanship, Polarization, and the Robustness of Support for Democracy in the United States." *American Political Science Review* 114, no. 2, 2020, pp. 392-409.

Optional:

- Levitsky, Steven and Daniel Ziblatt, *How Democracies Die* (New York: Crown), 2018.

Nov 30: Creating a world for autocracies?

- Besley, Tim and Masayuki Kudamatsu, "What Can We Learn from Successful Autocracies?" 2007. <https://voxeu.org/article/what-can-we-learn-successful-autocracies>
- Misçolu, Sergiu and Louis-Marie Kakdeu, "Authoritarian clientelism: the case of the president's 'creatures' in Cameroon," *Political Parties and Electoral Clientelism*. Cham: Springer Nature Switzerland, 2023, pp. 49-67.
- O'Brien, Kevin J., "Neither Withdrawal nor Resistance: Adapting to Increased Repression in China," *Modern China* 49 (1), 2023, pp. 3-25
- Podcast: Chen Weiss discussing "Making the world safe for autocracy": <https://supchina.com/podcast/making-the-world-safe-for-autocracy-jessica-chen-weiss-on-what-beijing-wants/>

Dec 7: **In-class final**

I. RESOURCES FOR STUDENTS

1. Some guiding questions to read critically:
 - What is the article's/book's main argument?
 - Why is it important? (e.g., why should we care about what the author or authors are writing about?)
 - What kind of evidence or how do the authors support their argument(s)?
 - o Is it good or valid evidence? Is it strong or weak?
 - o Are there any inconsistencies or issues that are not properly addressed?
 - How does the article or book contribute to the study of what we're interested in?
 - How does it compare with other scholarship about the topic we're interested in and what we have learned about thus far in class?
 - What are some weaknesses you can identify? Can those weaknesses be resolved or addressed by other authors or scholarship we have learned in class?
 - What is the article's/book's conclusion? What can we learn from it?
2. "10 Things to Know About Reading a Regression Table"
 - Evidence in Governance and Politics: <http://egap.org/methods-guides/10-things-know-about-reading-regression-table>
3. More resources on how to write an academic piece:
 - Purdue Online Writing Lab:
https://owl.purdue.edu/owl/general_writing/common_writing_assignments/research_papers/index.html (there are also resources on how to cite in this website).
 - USC Libraries Research Guides: <https://libguides.usc.edu/writingguide> (I'd recommend talking to the librarian as well. He can be a great resource in finding sources).